

RTET

■ By Sharda Ugra

Boy, that was quick. The moment India learnt its senior-most batsmen had opted out of September's Twenty20 World Cup, there was a stampede. Not towards the nearest street corner for a ritual round of protests, but to hammer out the tributes and order the bugler to sound the Last Post. Quick, before they change their minds.

The Twenty20 World Cup, cricket's ode to the microwave, is for young legs, quick wits and short attention spans. Rahul Dravid, Sachin Tendulkar and Sourav Ganguly have decided that their wits and skills are in good condition but their inner athlete is unlikely to rise and shine. With thinning pates and growing children, who needs more reminders about the generation gap? Who needs to dive, slide, and produce physiology-defying shots? Not such a tough choice, is it? Between the judgement of history and a verdict by popularity contest. Thanks guys, the microwave is all yours. The pressure cooker is more our thing.

It was as if relief was ringing out from rooftops in stereo. It had happened. The baton had been exchanged, thank god. The torch has been passed.

Not yet.

Soon it will be, but not just yet. In between that day and this, the light will slowly fade on a quartet like no other in Indian cricket history. Tendulkar, Dravid and Ganguly are top of the mind today, but ignore VVS Laxman and their collective mojo vapourises. These

four, India's most successful generation middle-order batsmen, perhaps its greatest ever batting generation are in England now at the start of what could be their last season together.

India has had many luminous batsmen, and a few great line-ups, but these four stand apart. Not merely because all feature amongst the top 10 Indian Test run-getters (300-odd more runs for Laxman in England and they will be four of the top eight). Their real distinction lies in their impact: at their peak, their runs and partnerships led to more Test victories than any other foursome India had ever fielded.

When the Tests in England begin, the group will be thrown up into the familiar swirl of affection and aggravation, kinship and rivalry. In the middle, they will try to re-discover the sync that builds when the scoreboard is hostile, the skies grey, the ball swinging, when all they have is each other. Eventually, one may keep going longer than the other, but

every man knows he will never keep such company again.

Before the Lord's Test, they are being paid a few cursory compliments but being told, in a very English way, that they are frankly a little passé. Ever since the World Cup, they have grown attuned to the impatient hissing.

When told about this article, one of them laughed and gave it a title, "The old boys' last stand, eh?" Their last two seasons have witnessed a tumult in fortunes, a spiralling of batting form and a jangling of confidence. Cool, green England, where cricket is organic

INDIA IN ENGLAND

July 13-15: England Lions v Indians, Chelmsford

July 19-23: First Test, Lord's

July 27-31: Second Test, Nottingham

Aug 3-5: Indians v Sri Lanka A, Leicester

Aug 9-13: Third Test, The Oval



BATTING BLITZ 2000 - 2004					
CRICKETERS	PLAYED	RUNS	AVG	100S	100 STANDS
RAHUL DRAVID	41	4034	69.55	11	27
SACHIN TENDULKAR	38	3484	61.32	11	HOME WINS
SOURAV GANGULY	38	2081	38.53	4	8
VVS LAXMAN	35	2786	58.89	6	AWAY WINS
					8

The years mentioned in the tables refer to the start and end of a cricket season, not a calendar year